

07

ISSUE

ISSUE 07 · THE PILOT THE FINDING ARGUES FOR

Before the Decision

The largest primary-data survey of migrants and refugees on the move has now told the sector, in its own words, what the sector's instruments have been failing to ask. The most useful reading is not accusatory. It is operational. The pilot the finding argues for is designable now.

In 2018 a distressed programme in Dakar survived not because a new strategy was written for it, but because the authority to design was returned to the community it served.

That sentence is the reading I keep going back to when a new finding lands in front of me. What worked at one site rarely worked because the analysis at headquarters got sharper. It worked because the people closest to the decision were given the room to shape the instrument they had been asked to receive.

The Mixed Migration Centre has now made the same reading available at cross-national scale.

THE FINDING AND WHAT IT CHANGES

Across five years, the MMC has assembled 103,235 face-to-face interviews with migrants and refugees on the move, in forty-three countries covering ninety-nine nationalities.¹

In the first quarter of 2026 the corpus put a new set of questions to a sub-sample of 2,390 respondents across ten nationalities and ten countries.²

Forty-five percent were aware of a legal pathway before leaving. Fifty-five percent were not. Of those who tried a legal pathway, fifty-three percent gave up because the cost was beyond reach. Fifty-nine percent said the enforcement they encountered had no impact on their decisions or on the continuation of the journey.

55%

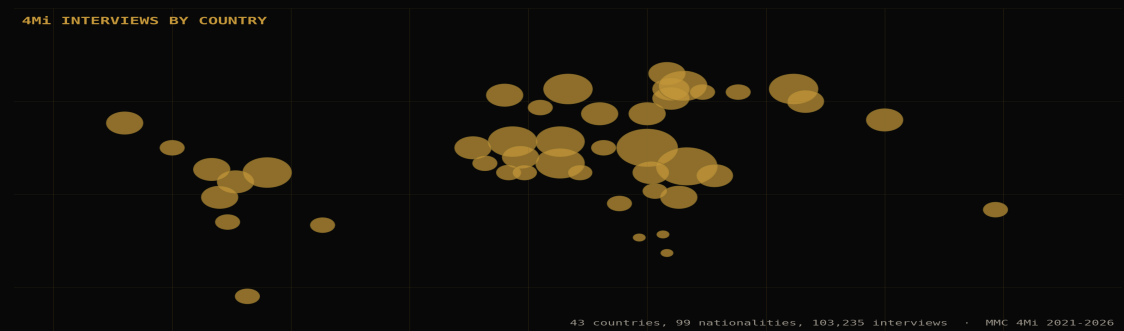
NOT AWARE OF THE LEGAL PATHWAY

53%

TRIED AND WERE PRICED OUT

59%

UNMOVED BY ENFORCEMENT

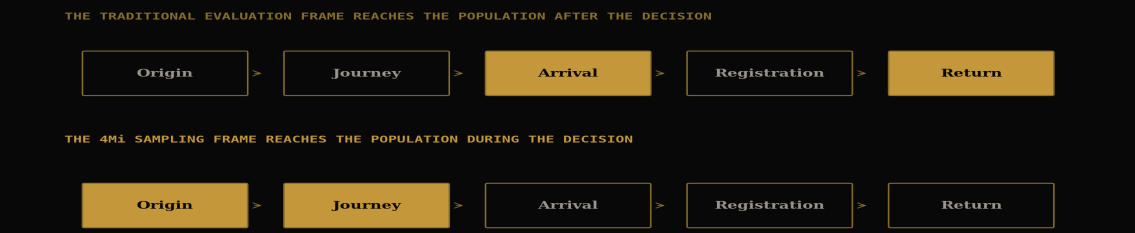


GEOGRAPHY OF THE 4Mi CORPUS · COUNTRIES OF INTERVIEW SIZED BY SHARE OF THE 103,235 TOTAL

The reading is not that the sector's instruments are worthless. The reading is that the instruments have been calibrated to a population whose awareness, resources, and responsiveness to enforcement did not match what the sub-sample reports.

Every legal-pathway policy carries three implicit assumptions. That the population knows the pathway exists. That where the pathway exists, the population who qualifies can afford to reach it. That enforcement changes the decisions the population makes along the route.

None of the three has ever been directly measured at cross-national scale, because the sampling frame of the evaluations that surround migration policy cannot reach the population before or during the decision.



THE THREE FINDINGS



MMC 4Mi Q1 2026, sub-sample n = 2,390 across 10 nationalities and 10 countries

THE AWARENESS GAP IS A TRUST GAP

The finding that fifty-five percent of respondents left without knowing a legal pathway existed is not evidence of an information failure. It is evidence of a trust failure.

An origin-country audience does not learn about a European or a Canadian legal pathway because a state agency published the pathway on a portal. It learns from a sister in Marseille. From a community organisation with a track record of telling the truth about what worked and what did not. From a diaspora-embedded messenger the applicant already trusts on other matters.

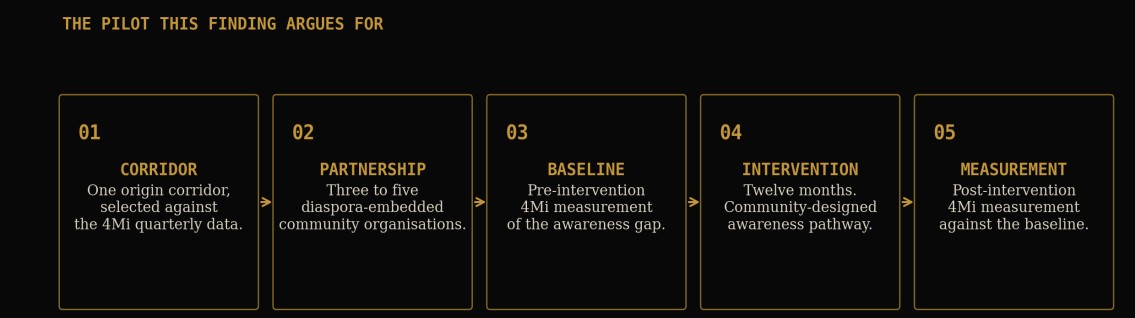
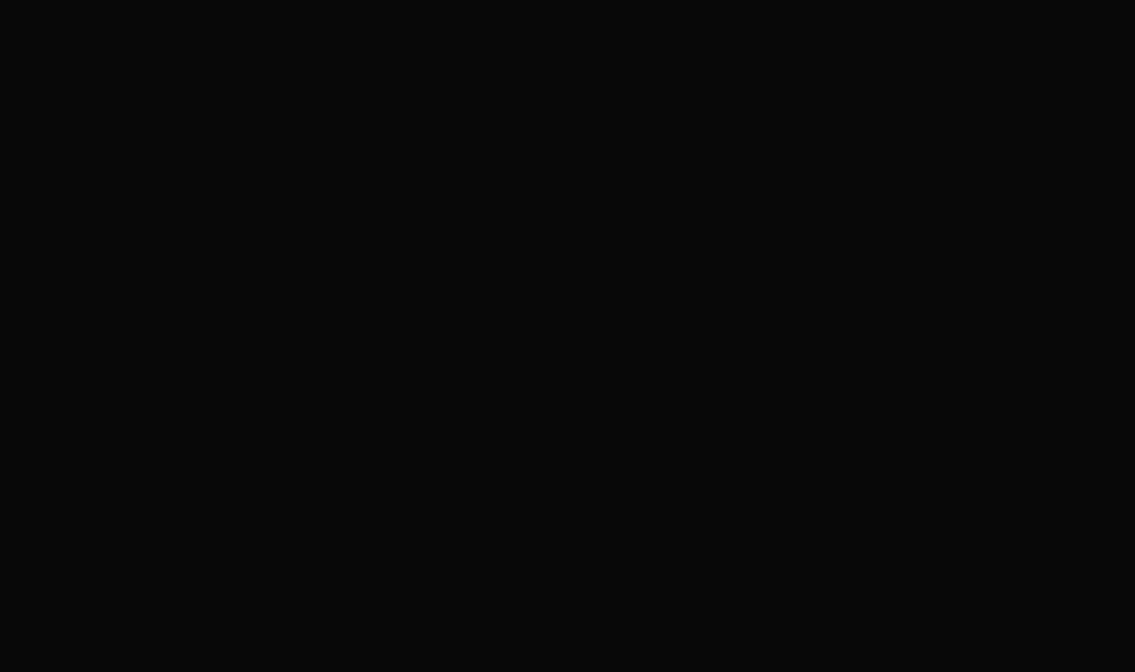
That is not a hypothesis about how information travels. It is what a decade of West Africa programme delivery would have told a designer of the current mobility partnerships, if the designer had been asking.

“The authority to design is returned to the community closest to the decision.”

THE ACCESS AND ENFORCEMENT GAPS

Fifty-three percent of those who tried a legal pathway abandoned it because the cost was beyond reach. Where the state prices its own channel above the addressable population's capacity, the population routes through the informal channel, whose price is not lower but whose access is compatible with an instalment. The finding suggests one durable design correction. Fee structures indexed to origin-country median income, with the total application cost capped at a share the addressable population can pay.

Fifty-nine percent reported that the enforcement they encountered did not alter their decision. The reading here is not political. It is an evaluation one. The 4Mi corpus makes the sampling frame available. Every enforcement programme evaluation over a threshold now has access to a primary-data measurement of the outcome the enforcement claims to produce.



ONE TO TWO MILLION EUROS · TWELVE-MONTH CYCLE · INSIDE THE AUTHORITY OF A SINGLE COUNTRY OFFICE

THE EVIDENCE BASE AND THE CHOICE

Nine adjacent primary-data sources converge on the conclusions the 4Mi has made visible from the population side. Massey and Riosmena on the historical failure of border enforcement to reduce the flow. Cornelius on the substitution effect. Hainmueller, Hangartner and Lawrence on the integration cost of extended irregular status. Vertier, Viskanic and Gamalerio on the political payoff of visible enforcement decoupled from migration effect. Sadiq on the population most affected by legal-pathway design being the one that never sees the paper. Andersson on the migration industry. The IOM Missing Migrants Project on the mortality of the substitution routes. Frontex Risk Analysis on detected crossings versus removals. The OECD International Migration Outlook on labour-migration channel utilisation.³⁻¹¹

The convergence is what the practitioner already carried in the room. The 4Mi is the point at which the convergence became measurable from the side that was previously invisible.

The sector's usual response is to commission a study of the finding. The alternative is that a country office or a foundation programme officer with the authority to fund a small pilot uses the 4Mi's own instrument to measure the awareness gap, funds a diaspora-embedded community partnership to close it, and lets the same instrument measure whether it moved.

“The research was never the hard part. The building is.”

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The Practitioner's Read is where I write about how institutions hold together under pressure, and the distance between what they claim and what they actually deliver.